

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

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Wealth and Poverty in the Wisdom Literature

The sayings in Scripture about wealth and poverty, especially in the wisdom literature, show a broad truth. God blesses wise people with wealth, which makes life's challenges easier to handle (Proverbs 3:9-10, 15-16; 10:22; 10:15). Foolish behavior, especially laziness, often leads to poverty (see 10:4).

The book of Proverbs acknowledges that some evil people who are foolish are wealthy, but it reminds us that this wealth will not last long (Proverbs 11:18; 13:11). Poverty can sometimes result from injustice rather than foolishness (13:23). Wealth can come from injustice and dishonesty (16:8). Those with wealth need to use it wisely, including being generous to those in need (28:27; 29:7, 14).

Wealth has limited benefits. Sometimes, it creates problems instead of solving them (Proverbs 11:4; 13:8). Wisdom can help in ways that wealth cannot, making wisdom more important than money (15:16-17; 16:8, 16).

God often blesses people who live to please him by providing what they need. When this happens, these people can then help others by sharing what they have received. This giving to others is itself another blessing from God. Yet, circumstances are not always fair. Sometimes, wealth does not go to those who deserve it (see Ecclesiastes 9:11). It does not always bring happiness (see Ecclesiastes 2:17-23; 5:10-17). In fact, money can harm faith (1 Timothy 6:10; James 2:1-13). When choosing between living to please God and money, wise people will choose living to please God.

Passages for Further Study

Deuteronomy 6:10-13; 8:10-11; 1 Samuel 2:7; Psalm 37:16; Proverbs 3:9-10, 15-16; 10:15, 22; 11:4, 18, 28; 13:8, 11; 14:24; 15:6, 16-17; 16:8, 16; 23:4-5; 28:27; 29:7, 14; Ecclesiastes 5:10-17; 1 Timothy 6:10

What Is Good

Micah 6:8, a famous and often memorized verse, answers questions from people who became confused and had lost their moral and spiritual direction.

The people of Israel wanted to know how to please the Lord. In a society full of lies and oppression, they forgot what the Lord considers good. God gave them a clear answer. God does not want people to worship

him by just following rules and ceremonies without meaning (Micah 6:6-7).

Instead, he wants them to do what is right in their relationship with him and with each other. When motivated by love, their actions should show justice, mercy, and humility. God's people should not oppress others but act justly, righteously, and honestly toward one another.

Micah 6:8 summarizes what God had already told Israel. Humility, faith, and obedience please God.

God shared this message:

- with Abraham (Genesis 15:6; 17:1, 9),
- with Moses at Sinai (Exodus 20-23),
- through his prophets (for example, Deuteronomy 6:1-8; Hosea 6:6), and
- through Israel's wise men (Proverbs 1:7).

It pleases God when people live humbly in faith, like:

- Moses (Numbers 12:3),
- Habakkuk (Habakkuk 3:17-19),
- Daniel (Daniel 9:1-19), and
- Ezra (Ezra 9:5-15).

True spirituality and devotion result in:

- doing good,
- seeking justice,
- helping the oppressed,
- defending orphans, and
- supporting widows (see Exodus 22:21-24; 23:2-12; Deuteronomy 15:4-11; 24:12-15; Nehemiah 5:1-13; Jeremiah 22:16; Daniel 4:27; Amos 5:7-24; James 1:27).

These actions reflect God's own character (Psalm 146:9; Matthew 11:5).

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 33:19; 34:6-7; Deuteronomy 8:3; 16:19-20; 1 Kings 3:11; Ezra 7:25; Nehemiah 9:31; Isaiah 2:9; 5:15; 30:18; 38:15; Daniel 9:18; Hosea 6:6; Amos 5:12, 15; Micah 6:8; Malachi 2:17; 3:15

Wisdom

Wisdom helps us know how to speak and act in various situations. It allows us to avoid problems and manage them when they happen. Wisdom is more than just intelligence. Proverbs mentions that even animals like ants, rock badgers, locusts, and lizards are wise (Proverbs 30:24-28). They are not wise because of great intelligence but because they know how to live skillfully.

The foundation of wisdom is God. No wisdom exists without “the fear of the LORD” (Proverbs 1:7). Wisdom is connected to righteousness and avoids evil.

According to Proverbs, people gain wisdom by:

- Observing and experiencing life (6:6–8)
- Learning from traditional teachings (22:17–21)
- Understanding mistakes (12:1)
- Most importantly, through revelation from God (see 1:7)

In 1 Corinthians 1–2, the apostle Paul compares the world’s “wisdom,” which he calls “foolishness,” with the wisdom of Jesus Christ. Paul also says about Jesus, “in whom are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge” (Colossians 2:3). God’s wisdom shows in Christians’ lives through their goodness, humility, purity, and peace (James 3:13–18).

Passages for Further Study

Deuteronomy 1:13–18; 4:5–8; 1 Kings 3:1–28; Job 12:12; 28:20–28; Psalms 90:12; 119:98; Proverbs 1:7; 2:1–22; 30:24–28; Ecclesiastes 2:12–16; 7:4–19; Isaiah 11:1–2; Jeremiah 9:23–24; 10:12; Hosea 14:9; Luke 7:35; 1 Corinthians 3:18–20; James 1:5; 3:13–17; Revelation 7:12

Wisdom Psalms

Some people call certain psalms “wisdom psalms” because they emphasize the importance of wisdom. They guide readers on handling life’s questions, issues, and doubts (see Psalms 1; 14; 25; 34; 37; 39; 49; 73; 78; 90; 91; 111; 112; 127; 128; 131; 133; 139). Many other psalms include wisdom teachings (see 18; 27; 31; 32; 40; 62; 92; 94; 107; 144; 146).

In the ancient Near East, wisdom involved:

- maintaining order
- pleasing the gods and others
- observing life, society, and nature

In Israel, wisdom focused on these areas but emphasized “the fear of the LORD.” God is the center of life, and fearing him leads to wisdom (111:10). “Fear of the LORD” means fully submitting to and trusting in him (115:11; see also 40:3; 112:7). This results in a pure life (19:9). Psalm 34 links the fear of the Lord with a life of plenty.

A life of wisdom means living in a way that pleases God. Psalm 1 invites everyone to find joy in God, his teachings, and the way of life that comes from his guidance for wise people. The lives of godly people show inner harmony, growth, and beauty. They reflect God’s righteousness, justice, love, faithfulness, com-

passion, and grace. They live to please God in both their hearts and their actions.

Wisdom expands a person’s perspective on life. A wise person wants to see life from God’s perspective. This search involves living with submission and trust under the sovereign king who keeps creation in order and harmony. Seeking God promotes an orderly and peaceful life and encourages obedience (19:7; 25:12; 51:6; 112:1; 119:98–100).

The wise imitate God, and their lives are joyful even during difficulties. They praise the Lord in all life situations (see 22:23, 25). They experience life with confidence because the Lord is with them (23:4; 27:1, 3; 33:18; 91:1–16).

The life of the fool, or the evil person, is opposite of the life of the wise. These people see themselves as powerful and always boast about their achievements. They do not accept limits. They brag, oppress, steal, and try to steal others’ happiness. They do not fear the Lord (36:1; 55:19). The poets of Israel often warned people to avoid the life of a “fool,” or God’s judgment might come to them (2:10–11; 94:8–10).

Jesus Christ entered the world as God in the flesh (he is fully God and fully human at the same time). He possesses all the qualities of wisdom. Through him, we can live a life of wisdom (Colossians 2:2–3).

Passages for Further Study

Psalms 1; 14; 25; 34; 37; 39; 49; 73; 78; 90; 91; 111; 112; 127; 128; 131; 133; 139

Women’s Roles in the New Testament Church

The apostle Paul’s words in 1 Timothy about women’s roles in the church were intended to correct what was happening in Ephesus. But Bible scholars debate how this passage applies to other situations. There are three main interpretations:

1. Universal Interpretation. Galatians 3:28 (“There is neither... male and female”) does not remove gender differences and roles created by God. Even if Galatians 3:28 shows the ideal of equality in God’s eternal kingdom, gender roles should follow the guidelines in 1 Timothy 2:11–15 as long as this world exists. For comparison, Matthew 22:30 talks about marriage in the new creation, which is different from the current structure described in Genesis 2:23–24. It applies to our current life in a special and limited way (see 1 Timothy 4:3–5; Matthew 19:11–12; 1 Corinthians 7:29–35). The new creation’s structure

is not yet fully realized until the future age and is not the ideal for now.

According to this view, Christian women everywhere must understand their role in God's created order. They should not teach or have authority over men in the church (see also 1 Corinthians 11:2-16; 14:34-35).

1. Polemical Interpretation. Paul addressed a specific issue caused by false teachings in the Ephesian church (see 1 Timothy 1:18-20; 4:1-5; compare 2 Timothy 3:6-9). Evidence shows this teaching was disrupting family relationships (see 1 Timothy 4:3; Titus 1:11). Some Ephesian women, influenced by local heresy, might have misused Genesis 1-3 in their teachings. They could have claimed that females will dominate in the final resurrection. Some Ephesians believed the resurrection had already happened (2 Timothy 2:18). They emphasized Adam was to blame for the first sin.

Paul corrected their misunderstandings by referring to the biblical text. But he did not intend to make a universal statement about women's roles in the church. His goal was to silence the false teachers in Ephesus, including the women involved. First Timothy 2:11-15 involves a rebuke with loss of privilege specifically for those false teachers.

1. Cultural Interpretation. Paul's argument was not necessarily intended for a local issue in Ephesus. It assumes a strongly patriarchal society (where men have most of the power and authority). This argument focuses on how women should behave in public (knowing their place and honoring men) and interpreting Genesis 2:7, 22. According to this view, Christians should respect cultural norms as much as possible in their mission to spread the good news about Jesus (1 Corinthians 9:19-23).

Also, most women in that society had limited education. Unlike many societies today, women in Paul's time usually received poor education. Because of their culture's male-dominated structure, women would not normally have qualified as teachers and leaders.

First Timothy 2:11-15 reflects the idea that properly qualified people should lead and teach. Yet, there are examples in Paul's writings and in the early church of women participating in various ministry roles (for example, Acts 18:26; Romans 16:1-7; 1 Corinthians 11:5). This raises questions about whether Paul's statements on women in the church apply to all times and places.

Christians continue to discuss these complex issues. Many Christians today hold a view called complementarianism (the belief that men and women have different but complementary roles and responsibilities in marriage, family life, and church leadership). Many

others hold an egalitarian view (the belief that men and women should have equal roles and responsibilities in the church). All Christians agree that men and women are equal as beloved children of God (see Galatians 3:26-28).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 2:23-24; Acts 18:26; Romans 16:1-7; 1 Corinthians 11:2-16; 1 Corinthians 14:34-35; Galatians 3:28; 1 Timothy 2:11-15

The Word

The apostle John begins his Gospel with an extraordinary description of Jesus Christ as "the Word" (Greek *logos*, John 1:1). In the first century, both Greek and Jewish listeners would understand the deep meaning of this title.

Greeks would think of the fundamental forces that sustain the universe. Jews would remember God creating the world by speaking (Genesis 1:3-28; Psalm 33:6, 9). In Jesus' time, the "Word" of God had gained creative personal qualities. Jews saw God's "Word" as another way of speaking about God's "Wisdom." Through Wisdom, God entered the universe, to create the world (Proverbs 8:22-31).

John explains that Jesus shares the same essence or nature as God. The Son existed before time and created everything. John connects the truth that Jesus is God to the ancient Jewish idea of Wisdom. This divine Wisdom, present with God before time, God now reveals in Jesus Christ. In a powerful verse, John writes that this *Logos*, or Wisdom, became a human person and lived among us (John 1:14). What God is, the *Logos* is, and the *Logos* is Jesus Christ.

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 1:3-28; Psalm 33:6, 9; Proverbs 8:22-31; Isaiah 40:8; John 1:1-18; 1 John 1:1; Revelation 19:13

Work and Patronage

When Paul visited the city of Thessalonica for the first time, he taught the new believers to earn their own money through work instead of relying on other people to support them.

Some Thessalonians refused to work. Paul addressed these lazy Christians in his first letter, but they did not change (1 Thessalonians 4:11-12; 5:14). Why did they refuse to work? They might have expected the Lord to return soon, so they stopped working. Yet, Paul's teachings about the Lord's return never oppose his basic instruction on the importance of work (2 Thessalonians 3:6, 10).

These lazy Christians might have been clients of influential patrons. Patronage was a key part of the Roman economy. Wealthy patrons often helped many clients by providing food, money, or public representation in court. Having many clients increased a patron's honor. Yet, being a client came with social duties that Paul wanted the Thessalonian Christians to avoid. This was especially important since their patrons were likely non-Christians.

Paul set an example for the Thessalonians. While he was with them, he financially supported himself (1 Thessalonians 2:9; 2 Thessalonians 3:7-9). Paul followed Jesus' teaching that, "the worker is worthy of his provisions" (see Matthew 10:10; 1 Corinthians 9:13-16). But he did not accept support from the Thessalonians (although he did accept offerings from the Philippians, Philippians 4:15-16). Paul wanted the Thessalonians to know he did not come to them using "words of flattery" to get money (1 Thessalonians 2:5, 9). He wanted them to learn from his example how they should live.

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 10:10; 1 Corinthians 9:13-16; Philippians 4:15-16; 1 Thessalonians 2:5, 9; 4:11-12; 5:14; 2 Thessalonians 3:6-10

The World

The book of John often uses the word "world" (Greek *kosmos*). In Greek-speaking Jewish thought, *kosmos* means the heavens and the earth created by God (Genesis 1; see also John 1:3, 10; 17:5, 24). The apostle John expands this idea to include humanity (for example, 1:10; 3:16).

Although God created it as good, the human world now opposes God (John 1:10-11; 3:19-20; 12:37-41). People love the darkness and cannot understand the light, actively resisting it (3:19). The world is without life and needs life (6:33, 51). Yet, it hates the one who can save it (7:7). Satan is the "prince of this world" (12:31). But he will encounter judgment one day.

God loves humanity, even though people often oppose and rebel against him. Jesus died to remove the world's sin (John 1:29; 3:16-17; 1 John 2:2). Yet, God's love for his creation exists alongside his need to judge the sin in the world (John 3:18-21, 36; 5:27-30; 12:47-48). Followers of Jesus feel this same tension in their mission. God calls us to share his love with the world. But we will encounter conflict because the world may oppose our message (see 15:18-27; 17:13-26).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 6:11-12; Psalms 2:1-6; 9:8; Isaiah 61:11; 66:16; Matthew 5:14; 13:38-40; John 1:9-10; 3:16-19; 7:7; 8:12; 14:17-19; 15:18-19; 16:7-9, 33; John 17:5-26; Acts 17:31; 1 Corinthians 1:20-28; 3:3; 6:2; 2 Corinthians 5:19; Ephesians 2:2; Colossians 2:20; James 4:4; 2 Peter 1:4; 2:20; 1 John 2:15-16; 4:3-5

Worship in Jerusalem

The Old Testament prophets understood that true worship requires knowing God and his expectations. God decided that the temple in Jerusalem would be the main place for his people's worship. The Lord's voice came from Zion and Jerusalem (Amos 1:2). It was not acceptable for the Israelites to create a central worship site anywhere other than the temple in Jerusalem.

After the Israelite kingdom split into two parts, Jeroboam, who was king of the northern kingdom, set up new places for worship. He tried to stop his people from traveling to Jerusalem to worship God. Over time, various worship sites appeared in both the northern and southern kingdoms. Yet, no matter how many sacrifices were made or how elaborate the ceremonies were, these were not the places God had chosen for worship (5:4-5).

In the New Testament, worship is not limited to a specific place. Christians can worship wherever they gather (see Matthew 18:20). Yet, worship must follow God's guidance "in spirit and in truth" (John 4:23-24). Both the Old and New Testaments stress the importance of genuine worship.

Passages for Further Study

Deuteronomy 12:5; 1 Kings 11:36; 2 Chronicles 6:6; Nehemiah 1:9; 11:1; Isaiah 2:3; 52:1; 56:7; Joel 3:17; Amos 5:4-5; Zechariah 8:20-22; Matthew 4:5; Luke 19:46; John 2:16; 4:21-24; Hebrews 12:18-29; Revelation 21:2, 10; 22:19

The Worship of Angels

Scripture often describes angels as beings that inspire awe or fear (for example, Joshua 5:13-15; Luke 2:8-10). Yet, angels serve God and he does not allow people to worship them (Hebrews 1:5-14; Revelation 19:10). Jewish tradition developed the idea of angels as mediators (those who connect others to God). In pre-Christian Judaism, people emphasized God's transcendence or "otherness" so much that they believed mediators were necessary to communicate with him. In this context, angels became more important.

For Christians, Jesus has a unique role as mediator between God and humans. Focusing on angels or

deceased saints as ways to communicate with God can distract from honoring Jesus as the only necessary mediator (1 Timothy 2:5–6; see also 2 Corinthians 5:19–21; Hebrews 7:24–25). God still uses angelic messengers, but they are creatures serving him, not divine beings to worship. Only God deserves our prayers and worship.

Passages for Further Study

Acts 27:23–24; 2 Corinthians 5:19–21; 1 Timothy 2:5–6; Hebrews 1:5–14; 7:24–25; Revelation 19:10

The Written Word

During the prophet Jeremiah's crisis at his public trial on the temple grounds, friends saved his life (Jeremiah 26). Yet, King Jehoiakim killed the prophet Uriah and tried to arrest Jeremiah. Would this end Jeremiah's public ministry? Was public speaking the only way to communicate the Lord's messages to Judah's leaders and people?

Killing and silencing the messengers did not stop the Lord's messages. The Lord can also effectively share his message in writing. The Lord told Jeremiah to write down all the messages he had preached (Jeremiah 36). Jeremiah had a helper named Baruch, who was skilled in writing and making copies.

While hiding, Jeremiah and Baruch bought a scroll (a paper roll made of papyrus) and prepared it to write the messages. When they finished writing, they read the scroll in the temple courtyard and to King Jehoiakim. The king cut up the scroll and burned it. But Jeremiah wrote the messages on a new scroll, adding new material. For the rest of Jeremiah's ministry, he wrote his messages on papyrus. Then he sent them to leaders of various countries and to the Israelite exiles in Babylon (see Jeremiah 29).

The first instance of writing God's word of course appears in Exodus. God instructed Moses to write the words of the covenant (Exodus 24:4, also see Exodus 17:14). It specifically states that Moses wrote the book of Deuteronomy (Deuteronomy 31:9, 24). The existence of the written law likely started a tradition of documenting God's revelations (Joshua 24:26; 1 Samuel 10:25; 1 Chronicles 29:29; 2 Chronicles 9:29; Isaiah 8:16–17; 30:8). It seems that prophets recorded many of Israel's historical writings (see 2 Chronicles 12:15; 13:22).

Communities preserved these documents for a long time, especially those written on leather scrolls. They made many copies from one document. These copies were so valuable that people carefully preserved them

for centuries. They also translated the copies into many languages.

The book of Jeremiah and the writings of other prophets, wise men, and teachers have become preserved, collected, and handed down to us as the Old and New Testaments. These texts provide a written record of God's messages to his people (see 2 Timothy 3:16–17; 2 Peter 1:20–21).

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 17:14; 31:18; 34:27–28; Deuteronomy 31:9–13; Isaiah 30:8; Jeremiah 30:2–3; Jeremiah 36:1–32; 45:1; 51:60–64; Ezekiel 43:11; Daniel 7:1; Luke 1:1–4; John 5:46–47; 20:30–31; 21:24–25; Acts 1:1–2; Romans 15:4; 1 Corinthians 10:11; 2 Timothy 3:16–17; Philemon 1:21; Hebrews 13:22; 1 Peter 5:12; 2 Peter 1:20–21; 1 John 1:4; 2:12–24; 5:13; Revelation 1:11; 10:4; 21:5; 22:18–19